

The Plain Dealer | Sunday, February 17, 2002

DIVISION I SECTIONAL WRESTLING

Recovering Mustangs dominate

PAT GALBINCEA
Plain Dealer Reporter

In past years, winning a sectional title was a big deal for Strongsville wrestlers.

Not this year. The Mustangs are looking for bigger results in Columbus after dominating a good field in the Division I sectional at North Royalton last night.

Strongsville topped runner-up Garfield Heights, 27½ points to 221, with eight individual champions in seniors Frank Passafiume (119 pounds), Ryan Allen (135), Pete Gasparro (152), Kevin Ryan (160) and heavyweight Meena Henen, junior Matt White (130) and his senior brother Brad White (130), and junior Justin Ludwig (145).

The Mustangs have overcome an injury riddled season.

"We've had three separated

shoulders, two ineligibilities, one case of [mononucleosis], one case of kidney stones, one concussion, one broken thumb and one [anterior cruciate ligament] tear among 10 starters," Strongsville coach Steve Cika said. "So, I hope we're rewarded at the end of the season."

"I think our brutal schedule is a reason we've looked good lately. Our schedule is comparable to St. Ed's, except we didn't wrestle in the Beast of the East."

Cika makes good points, based on what happened in the afternoon semifinals. Ludwig got a third-period takedown and a near fall to stun top-seeded Doug Thomas of Bedford, 10-3.

In the finals, Ludwig trailed Delvin Talton of Lincoln-West, 7-3, midway through the match but, midway, 12-9, with a five-point upper-body throw in the last 10 seconds.

Sheer persistence enabled Henen to wear down top-seeded Luis Plata of Lincoln-West and pin him in 5:10. Plata outweighed Henen by 50 pounds. Henen then bridged off his back from an upper-body throw by Ray Rowe of St. Ignatius in the finals, a key to his 8-7 victory.

State qualifier Gasparro, who used two takedowns and leg wrestling to beat Garfield Heights ace sophomore Brad Bugara, but the latter came on strong with three reversals. Hunt hung on to win, 12-10.

Moore had no such problems, picking the right spots to use explosive moves and his strength to beat Mustangs junior Mike Wallace, 13-2.

Wornoff beat North Royalton junior Chuck Pedro, 9-5, with four precision takedowns.

Pflug (145).

Cleveland John F. Kennedy had two impressive champions in sophomores Jayrl Hunt (103) and Bruce Moore (171), and Garfield Heights had two title winners in Joe Wornoff (112) and Luke Stachowicz (139).

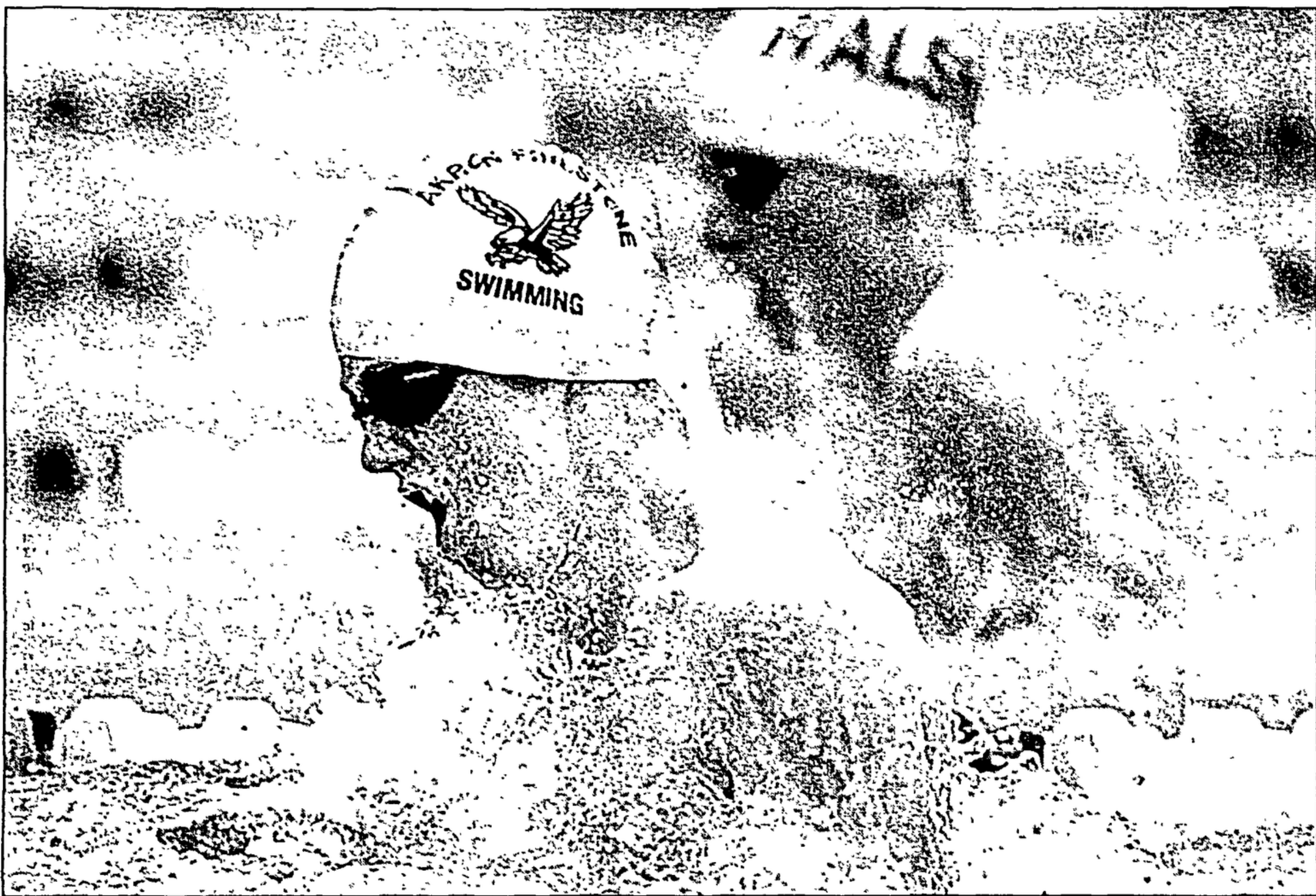
Hunt used high-crotch, single-leg and duck-under takedowns to build an 8-3 lead on Garfield Heights sophomore Brad Bugara, but the latter came on strong with three reversals. Hunt hung on to win, 12-10.

Moore had no such problems, picking the right spots to use explosive moves and his strength to beat Mustangs junior Mike Wallace, 13-2.

Wornoff beat North Royalton junior Chuck Pedro, 9-5, with four precision takedowns.

Contact Pat Galbincea at: pgalbincea@plained.com, 216-999-4677

DISTRICT SWIMMING



GUS CHAN | THE PLAIN DEALER

Firestone's Chris Ash swims the finals of the 100-yard breaststroke, followed by Walsh Jesuit's Steve Marshall. Ash finished second; Marshall was fifth.

Firestone, Hawken coast
Falcons boys, Hawks girls lead area qualifiers for stateMIKE PETICCA
Plain Dealer Reporter

Firestone's boys and Hawken's girls will swim against challenging opponents at next weekend's state meet in Canton.

The difference is, Firestone's top opponent will be all too real; Hawken's will be pretend.

Firestone and defending state champion Cincinnati St. Xavier will be the featured boys matchup Thursday through Friday in Brantin Natatorium. The Falcons won yesterday's district meet at Cleveland State's Busby Natatorium, compiling 391 points to 197 for second-place University School.

"This will be our best shot," coach Tim Lewarchick said of Firestone's chances to win a state title for the first time since 1983. "It's St. Xavier's meet to lose, though. We're going to have to swim our best and get a

lot of help from everybody else in the state."

Meanwhile, Hawken will be a heavy favorite to win its fourth consecutive girls championship and third straight in Division II. The Hawks have worn the state crown 13 times. Yesterday, Hawken totaled 474 points to 229 for runner-up Rocky River.

"We're going to be competing against Division I, too, even though we won't be swimming against them," Hawken senior Lauren Torpey said. "We're going to compare our times to theirs. We want to be not only the best team in Division II, but the best team in the state."

While Firestone and Hawken have lofty aspirations, Magnificat's girls might settle for a bit less. The Blue Streaks took first in Division I yesterday with 300 points, 45 more than Firestone's girls.

"We're a stronger team than

last year," said senior Lindsey Jerdonek, who helped Magnificat to an eighth-place state finish in 2001. "We're hoping to get in the top five next week."

Firestone's boys had first-place showings in seven of 12 district events, including three of six yesterday. Senior Jon Albrecht, who won the 200-yard freestyle Friday, was first in the 100 freestyle yesterday. His time of 45.79 seconds is the best this season in The Plain Dealer's seven-county coverage area. Albrecht also anchored the Falcons' first-place 400 freestyle relay (3:10.41), following teammates Evan Staiger, Chris Stoneburg and Michael Jones. Jones won the 100 backstroke (52.45) after winning the 200 individual medley Friday.

The Falcons, who were third at last year's state meet, defeated St. Xavier at the Big 8 Meet two months ago at Brantin. "I think

we're all fired up already," Albrecht said. "I think about St. Xavier every time I swim."

Hawken was first in six events, including three yesterday. Freshman Alyssa Kiel, Friday's winner in the 200 freestyle, was first yesterday in the 500 freestyle (area-best 4:53.30). Kiel led off the first-place 400 freestyle relay (3:38.17), followed by teammates Anna Strohl, Christina Marshall and Torpey. Andria Johnson, Eileen Starrett, Kiel and Julieann Watson swam the winning 200 freestyle relay (1:40.53).

Magnificat's victory was highlighted by its winning the 400 freestyle relay (area-best 3:34.73) on the work of Melissa Froelich, Audrey Gedeon, Allison Kay and Jerdonek. Friday's 50 freestyle was won by Jerdonek.

Contact Mike Peticca at: mpeticca@plained.com, 440-602-4785

DISTRICT SWIMMING NOTES

Crestwood's Groselle gets icing on cake

MIKE PETICCA
Plain Dealer Reporter

Crestwood senior Beth Groselle got more than she bargained for at yesterday's district swim meet at Cleveland State.

"I just wanted to make it to state," Groselle said after finishing first twice in the span of barely one hour. "I didn't care about place. That just happened."

Groselle's winning time of 58.91 in the 100-yard backstroke is the best this season in The Plain Dealer's seven-county coverage area. She also was first in the 100 breaststroke (1:07.27). Groselle placed second and third, respectively, at last year's state meet in the 200 individual medley and the 100 backstroke.

Sophomore Ellis Schieman of Shaker Heights also won two titles, placing first among Division I girls yesterday in the 500 freestyle (5:03.23) after winning Friday's 200 freestyle.

Below par: Chagrin Falls junior Lauren Preyss set lofty standards for herself last season, winning state titles by setting Division II state records in the 100 (51.78) and 200 (1:51.60) freestyles. Yesterday, she won the 100 (53.28), but she wouldn't know until late last night if her fourth-place finish in Friday's 200 freestyle would earn her an at-large qualifying berth for the state meet — although her time of 1:55.27 was likely good enough to get her there.

"I've always liked the 100 better than the 200," Preyss said. "[Yesterday] I was a little more comfortable and relaxed."

Best of the best: Firestone's girls, second to Magnificat in Division I, got an area-best time of 1:39.08 from the 200 freestyle relay team of Theresa Cunniff, Danielle Dieterich, Emmy Fulkman and Amanda Burwell.

Solon senior Matt Fallon and sophomore Amy Mertens established area-best times in the boys and girls 100 breaststrokes (58.72 and 1:06.80, respectively).

Fallon, who has qualified individually for the state meet eight times in four years, won an individual district title for the first

time. He would have thought about his misses if he hadn't. "I think there always would have been 'would've, could've, should've,'" Fallon said.

There they go: University School's second-place boys finish was highlighted by a first-place swim for the 200 freestyle relay team of Mark Levendorf, Andrew Neff, Arnaud Thibbonier and Topper Sine. The Preppers' time of 1:26.96 earned them a surprising win over runner-up Firestone (1:27.10).

"It is an upset, but Firestone didn't shave down for this meet," said a shaven Sine. "But it is pretty nice that we out-touched them there at the end."

Contact Mike Peticca at: mpeticca@plained.com, 440-602-4785

Sports | C17

DIVISION III SECTIONAL WRESTLING

Firebirds run away with Brooklyn title

BOB MIGRA
Plain Dealer Reporter

St. Peter Chanel's wrestlers are a year older and a year wiser.

Last season, the Firebirds finished 1½ points behind St. Vincent-St. Mary in the Division III state tournament. There was no shortage of "what ifs" in Chanel's failed bid for a state championship.

Last night, the Firebirds looked like a team determined to erase any wiggle room for the opposition while running away with the Brooklyn sectional championship. The Firebirds advanced all 14 wrestlers to next week's district tournament at Elyria Catholic and claimed nine champions.

"We wrestled fantastic," Chanel coach Graham Coghill said. "And we wrestled smart. You have to be smart. This is a sport where you do what you have to do. Sometimes, when the other guy is losing, you don't want to take chances, just let them make the mistakes and then take advantage."

The Firebirds took advantage of the opposition to the tune of 287½ team points. Cuyahoga Heights was second with 144½ points, followed by Cuyahoga Valley Christian Academy with 113 points.

Jeff Monsman (112 pounds), Frank Paparone (119), J. Jagers (125), Dan Ralph (135), brothers Ryan (145) and Nick Roppel (160), T. Terry (171), Mark Zarnace (215) and heavyweight Alan Dalide won championships for the Firebirds.

Monsman, a state champion last season, needed an escape in the second overtime for a 3-2 decision over Adam Lint of Cuyahoga Heights. Monsman forced the first overtime by escaping with 30 seconds left in the third period.

"He's definitely a tough kid," Monsman said. "I'll see plenty of him in the next two weeks. It'll be a battle."

Jagers, another returning

state champion, defeated Keystone's Jason Bernath, 18-6, in a battle of unbeaten wrestlers. Jagers improved to 34-0. Bernath lost for the first time after 34 victories.

"He's tough," Jagers said. "I caught him last year and pinned him, but we've both improved a lot. I wouldn't be surprised if I saw him in the finals the next two weeks."

Cuyahoga Heights brought just 10 wrestlers to the tournament, and eight advanced. Derek Meyers (130) and Adam Foote (152) won championships for Cuyahoga Heights.

"We're pretty happy to take second in this tournament," Redskins coach Dan Milkovich said. "We placed ahead of some pretty good full teams. We're a fairly young team, and it's important for our younger guys to get through to get the experience."

Meyers scored a takedown with 12 seconds left to wrap up a 4-2 victory over CVCA's Matt Smilek. Smilek finished third in the state last season.

"It felt pretty good," Meyers said. "I was just trying to block his singles and take advantage of his bad shots. It's starting to come together for us."

Matt Sammons (140) and Mike Turnbull (189) won championships for CVCA.

Jacob Bill became just the second wrestler from Clearview to win a sectional championship when he scored a takedown 13 seconds into overtime for a 3-1 victory over Braxton Scaletta of Cuyahoga Heights in the 103-pound finals.

Bill (45-1) dodged a high shot by Scaletta, then finished the match with a double-leg takedown. He is looking to become Clearview's first state qualifier since 1978.

"I had to use some defense, because I couldn't overpower him with my offense," Bill said. "This feels great."

Contact Bob Migra at: bmigra@plained.com, 216-999-4744

DIVISION II SECTIONAL WRESTLING

Zupancic puts halt to Deubel's streak

TIM WARSINSKEY
Plain Dealer Reporter

Kenston sophomore Ricky Deubel's 66-match winning streak is over, but the fun is just beginning in the 119-pound weight class.

Walsh Jesuit's Josh Zupancic handed Deubel his first career defeat, winning by criteria in overtime in a highly anticipated final during last night's Division II wrestling sectional at Kenston.

The match had a near-capacity crowd on its feet and roaring, but it merely set the stage for what could be in store for the pair.

Both wrestlers advanced to this week's district tournament at Firestone, where they are favored to reach the finals again. And they quite possibly could see each other at the state meet in what is regarded by some as the toughest weight class in the state.

"I'll have to do it a couple of more times to win a state title," said Zupancic, a junior and a two-time state runner-up. "This [victory] doesn't really mean anything."

Deubel (30-1), a state champion at 103 pounds last year, felt the same way about his winning streak.

"All I care about is being a four-time state champ," he said. "I'd rather lose now than at state."

Zupancic's victory highlighted a successful weekend for Walsh, which won the tournament with 262 points and produced 12 district qualifiers with five sectional champions. Runner-up Kenston (256½ points) had 13 district qualifiers and two champions.

Wrestling each other for the first time, Zupancic and Deubel were tied, 4-4, through three periods with each wrestler scoring one takedown. Neither scored in overtime, although Deubel just missed on a front headlock. In the second overtime, Deubel chose the down position and had



Zupancic

30 seconds to escape or reverse to win the match.

Zupancic (32-6) held on to Deubel's lower legs, which had Kenston coaches and fans screaming for stalling. A rule change instituted before this season allows the wrestler on top much more leeway during overtime, which Zupancic said he knew. Zupancic already had given up a point for stalling, and another stalling call would have cost him the match. Two stalemates were called, and Zupancic held on to Deubel's legs after each restart.

Kenston coaches argued Zupancic was required to move up on Deubel's legs after the first stalemate, which Zupancic did not appear to do.

The top five schools combined to capture 44 of the 56 district tournament berths at stake. Aurora has seven district qualifiers, and Twinsburg and Springfield each has six.

Akron Springfield junior Jordan LaFollette, a Division I state champion at 103 last year, defeated Walsh junior Danny Sandy in the 112-pound final, 10-4.

Walsh freshman Mike Pucillo, who missed most of the season with a shoulder injury, stunned the 125-pound field by beating state qualifier Brian Faist of Kenston in the semifinals, 3-1, and Twinsburg state place-winner Colby Turchetta in the final, 13-1. A takedown in the last four seconds gave Walsh's Scott Marhoffer an 11-9 victory over Tallmadge's Matt Cuva in the 160-pound final.

Other champions were Springfield's Nick Porter (103) and Pat Ternosky (215), Kenmore's Jermain Thompson (130), Twinsburg's Chad Turchetta (135) and Mike Berquist (152). Walsh's Dave Garner (140) and John Lowrey (171), Kenston's Josh Ging (145) and Robert Uhl (heavyweight), Orange's Jaren Carter (189) and Revere's Eddie Johnson (215).

Contact Tim Warsinsky at: twarsinsky@plained.com, 440-602-4784